

A Bus Comes to the Village

Mrs. Grace managed a newsstand in the village. The newsstand was only half a minute's walk from the entrance of the village. Anyone back home would see this newsstand first, then Mrs. Grace's spirited figure behind the newsstand's window, and last the village itself.

Every dawn when the first beam hit the ground, Mrs. Grace was ready to cope with her morning rush hour.

"Newspaper, Mrs. Grace!"

"Pay me later!"

Mrs. Grace shot the rolled newspaper out of the window. It described a smooth arc to the buyer's hand. Three or five students on bicycles passed by, rounded their lips, and whistled, "Bravo!"

"Boys, take your sandwiches! Today's double cheese!"

The sandwiches on a little table placed in front of the newsstand disappeared hastily, only to leave a ripple of "love ya auntie".

At dusk, the other rush hour came to Mrs. Grace. Everyone that credited Mrs. Grace's goods went back and crowded at the window of the newsstand.

Mrs. Grace unfolded the folding table and brought a money box on it. The pine-made box was non-covered, with all four corners polished soft and smooth. People dropped changes into the box. Coins hit coins, uttering a lilting sound of *ding*.

Usually, it was also the time when Mrs. Grace's cookies were ready. So people paid off the bill stuck to the open space in front of the newsstand, trying everything to stall for time: the carpenter sat down on his toolbox by his bike and then stretched his arm to grab newspaper in the

bike pannier; diligent students talked about their homework; a small group of young men gathered up to share one cigarette.

Kids who were tempted by the smell of cookies mingled with a breeze would too come. They were brilliant accountants - assiduously counting the flowers planted behind Mrs. Grace's newsstand.

"Mrs. Grace." A little girl slid into the newsstand and tugged on Mrs. Grace's hemline.

"Yeah? What's up, sweetie?" Mrs. Grace took out a tray with an oven glove.

"Everyone's energetic but Fiona. She has only thirty-two family members now," Fiona was this little girl's favorite flower clump, so only it had a name. "Granny Brown counted three times and said two of them had been dead."

"Oh, honey, Fiona will get better. Here, take some cookies, then you'll feel better, too."

Then, Mrs. Grace served a tray full of cookies on the table outside, picked out some to a plate, and went to her backyard. On the way she caught some boys smoking.

"Hey gentlemen, Mrs. Grace don't like smoke."

The boy who was just enjoying nicotine flicked the cigarette off his lips, and bow to apologize.

Mrs. Grace stuffed cookies into their mouths one after another as a reward.

After, she came to sit beside Granny Brown in the backyard.

"Mrs. Brown, have some cookies?"

"You're Grace, I know."

"Right, sis," Mrs. Grace said, "cookies?"

"Ah," Granny Brown licked her lips, "cookies. I like cookies."

They ate cookies.

“Where’s my son, you know?” The granny babbled.

Mrs. Grace answered her.

“Where’s my cookie? It was in my hand.”

And Mrs. Grace answered.

The chat flowed until Old Brown came to take his wife home.

Granny Brown always arrived at noon, accompanied Mrs. Grace in baking cookies, and went home. That was an Alzheimer's granny's routine.

After everything fell into tranquility, the newsstand turned into Mrs. Grace's home. That was Mrs. Grace's routine.

This day, before Mrs. Grace's dusk rush hour, she met a man stepping out of a car.

A fresh face wandered and looked around, noting down something from time to time.

Mrs. Grace saw him. She set up her table and wiped her hands on her apron and went to that man.

“Good afternoon, sir. Need any help?”

“No, thanks.” The man said, “But, uh, is that cottage yours, Mrs...”

“Grace.”

“Mrs. Grace, good. Is that yours?” He pointed to the newsstand.

“It's shared, but folks allow me to live here.”

The man shrugged, “Well, Mrs. Grace, you'd better find another good place.”

“Sorry?”

The man said a bus stop would be built here, and her cottage would also be rebuilt into a real newsstand - only allowing newspaper and bottled water.

Mrs. Grace was astonished.

He shrugged, "Sorry, but I'm just a messenger." The car spewed up a cloud of carbon emissions.

Mrs. Grace choked on it, so much.

The bus stop was set up quickly. The day after its establishment, Mrs. Grace's oven was sent somewhere else. The next day, Mrs. Grace's newsstand was painted dark green. Another day later, a country bus entered the village.

The bus stop was in front of the government's dark green newsstand, where Mrs. Grace's food table used to be.

Students left their bicycles at home; they bussed to school.

No sandwiches or cookies, no bike bell rings, no "love ya auntie".

Mr. Carpenter stuck to buying a newspaper at first, till one day he came to Mrs. Grace and said that he decided to leave for the city.

"Oh! That's...It's so sudden!"

"No, Grace, I've thought of this day." He grabbed some coins out and then shove the newspaper into his pocket. Coins dropped on the bottom of the wooden box, making a dull sound. "Now everything, even money boxes metallic. It's hard to find wooden stuff to be repaired, you know? People just throw them."

"Take care, Grace. Next time we meet," Last Mr. Carpenter grinned, "perhaps you'd call me Mr. Blacksmith."

Now only Mrs. Grace and a granny here - all flowers died, probably because of vehicle exhaust; kids weren't allowed to come since the bus was scratched and the messenger man insisted children's parents pay for their carelessness of letting kids behave badly, though there was no evidence showing kids did that.

The man shrugged, "I'm just a messenger."

The next day a surveillance camera was installed under the newsstand's front eave.

Breathing in bus exhaust every day, Mrs. Grace coughed worse and worse. Her son living downtown told her bus to the last stop and he'd take her to the doctor. So this day Mrs. Grace waved goodbye to Granny Brown.

Now only granny was there.

The next day, the newsstand got empty.

The monitor recorded that, a granny always murmuring got on the bus. And she waved an arm towards the bus window.

No one knew where bus take her to.